Choice Begins Before Choice

Meaning-Shaped Accessibility, Live Possibility, and Effective Agency in Human-AI Systems

A strong-form synthesis of Agency Potential, Experience Is Meaning-Giving, Human LoRA, Fusion/Tunnel, and CTSA Human Return

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Status. K0 strong-form conceptual and measurement architecture. The paper does not claim a metaphysical theory of free will or a validated universal scale of human agency. It advances a narrower but strong thesis: human choice is downstream of a meaning-shaped field of *live possibilities*. A policy or action can be physically possible and even structurally feasible while remaining practically absent from the agent's current field of consideration because it is unreadable, unnameable, unintelligible, normatively unavailable, affectively blocked, or historically inaccessible. Power, learning, violence, institutions, relationships, and AI can therefore alter agency before overt choice by changing which possibilities become live. This claim is constrained by explicit non-collapse laws, causal and counterfactual requirements, and deletion conditions.

Central claim. Human beings do not choose from the whole space of what is objectively possible. They choose from a history-shaped subset of possibilities that have become sufficiently meaningful, accessible, discriminable, and actionable to enter practical consideration. **Choice therefore begins before choice.** Experience gives meaning to phenomena; retained experience changes future readout; resonance can make some possibilities feel fitted to prior experience; rhythm and repeated traversal can make some routes easier to re-enter; social structures can enable or suppress conversion from possibility to action; and Human-AI interaction can recursively reshape the state from which the next prompt and choice are generated. Effective agency is therefore not merely the presence of options or the occurrence of action, but the corrigible capacity to read live differences, own a decision, causally enact it, and preserve routes of objection and revision. **Power can act on agency by acting on meaning before it acts on choice.**

1. Abstract

Theories of agency often begin where choice becomes visible: preference, deliberation, decision, action, or outcome. This paper argues that an analytically prior layer is required. Human beings do not deliberate over the full set of objectively possible actions; they deliberate over a history-shaped field of *live possibilities*: options that have become sufficiently meaningful, accessible, discriminable, and actionable for a situated agent to treat them as real candidates. The central thesis is therefore *choice begins before choice*. The paper develops this claim by joining two strands of the Human-AI Readout Programme. *Effective, Corrigible Agency Potential* models agency as a task- and context-relative envelope of feasible, actor-directed, causally effective, and corrigible readout-action loops. *Experience Is Meaning-Giving* models experience as the relation through which phenomena become significant for an embodied, history-bearing reader. Their synthesis exposes a missing interface: between objective or structural possibility and overt choice lies a meaning-shaped accessibility field.

The paper distinguishes six levels that are often collapsed: physically possible, structurally feasible, experientially live, chosen, enacted, and evaluator-visible. It introduces a *Live Possibility Field* as a domain-level object and shows how meaning-giving, autobiographical and affective significance, resonance, rhythmic recurrence, semantic attraction, recent-path momentum, retention, and social interpretation can alter the probability that a feasible option becomes practically thinkable. This does not imply that every unconsidered option was suppressed, that all social influence is domination, or that felt resonance is consent. Structural deprivation requires a feasible counterfactual, a named causal mechanism, and an independent normative reason why the closure is harmful or unjust.

The framework is placed in dialogue with Sen, Kabeer, Emirbayer and Mische, Bazzani, Foucault, Pettit, Fricker, Mahmood, Galtung, empowerment theory, and recent Human-AI feedback research. It then extends the Pre-Prompt Human State Principle: AI may alter agency not only by recommending an action but by changing which distinctions, questions, and alternatives become live before the next prompt. The resulting empirical programme asks whether live-possibility measures add out-of-sample explanatory value beyond resources, stated preferences, option count, arousal, familiarity, schema activation, and current prompt content. The strongest implication is methodological and political: to assess human potential, freedom, violence, learning, or AI influence, one must ask not only *what did the person choose?* but *what could become a live choice for this person, under this history and structure, and what made other possibilities disappear from practical view?*

2. The Residual Problem: The Missing Layer Before Choice

The agency-potential work already separates a decision that was actually taken from the envelope of policies that could be accessed, used, or learned within declared time and resource constraints [1]. The experience theory adds that the human reader does not encounter the world as neutral data: phenomena become experience through meaning-giving, and retained experience can alter the operator through which later situations become significant [2, 3]. These two results imply a missing layer.

A person can face an option that is physically open and legally permitted, yet not experience it as a real option. The option may be unknown, unnameable, culturally unintelligible, emotionally unapproachable, socially punishable, conceptually unavailable, or absent from the agent's current problem representation. Conversely, an option may become intensely salient without being objectively feasible or epistemically warranted. Choice therefore cannot be modeled as a direct mapping from an objective option set to a selected action.

The strong-form sequence is:

world / structure → meaning-shaped readout → live possibility field → choice → action → feedback → retained future reader.

The claim is not that deliberation is unreal. It is that deliberation is downstream of a prior selection problem: *which possibilities become candidates for deliberation at all?*

3. Internal Genealogy: From Potential to Live Possibility

The present paper does not replace prior programme objects. It makes their dependency relation explicit.

The new residual interface is therefore:

> *Between what a person could in principle do and what the person actually chooses lies a history-shaped field of possibilities that have become sufficiently meaningful and accessible to count as live candidates.*

4. External Literature: What Is Already Known, and What Remains

The thesis has close neighbors and should not be sold as if agency theory had ignored structure, temporality, power, or interpretation.

4.1 Agency, capability, and the conditions of choice

Sen distinguishes agency from well-being and insists that a person's pursuit of goals and values cannot be reduced to personal welfare [7]. Kabeer explicitly analyzes empowerment through resources, agency, and achievements and qualifies choice by its conditions, content, and consequences [8]. These are direct constraints on any claim that agency can be inferred from outcomes or resource possession alone.

Bazzani's account of agency as a conversion process is an especially close neighbor: agency is situated in micro-, meso-, and macro-level conversion factors and temporal processes rather than treated as an abstract possession [10]. The present paper therefore does not claim novelty for the proposition that context converts resources into effective agency. Its residual contribution is the explicit placement of a meaning-shaped *live possibility field* between feasible capacity and overt choice, together with a readout/visibility audit and Human-AI extension.

4.2 Agency is temporally embedded

Emirbayer and Mische conceptualize agency as a temporally embedded process combining iterational, projective, and practical-evaluative dimensions [9]. This strongly supports the refusal to treat choice as a history-free instant. The present architecture adds a narrower claim: temporal history may alter not only how a known option is evaluated but whether the option becomes sufficiently accessible to function as a live candidate.

4.3 Power can act on the field of possible action

Foucault's account of power is structurally relevant because power acts upon the possible actions of others rather than only through direct force [11]. Pettit's non-domination likewise shows why the absence of actual interference is insufficient for freedom: arbitrary capacity to interfere can alter the choice situation even when no intervention occurs [12]. These traditions already defeat any simplistic equation of freedom with unblocked motion.

The present thesis sharpens one interface: power can operate not only by removing an option after it is recognized but by altering the conditions under which the option becomes intelligible, permissible, credible, or practically available to the agent. This is a meaning-and-accessibility claim, not a replacement for broader theories of domination.

4.4 Epistemic and interpretive resources

Fricker's hermeneutical injustice identifies cases in which prejudicial flaws in shared interpretive resources obstruct a person's capacity to render significant areas of social experience intelligible [13]. This is a direct neighbor of the present claim that unnameability and interpretive scarcity can reduce the live possibility field. The framework therefore must not present "meaning access" as a newly discovered problem. Its contribution is to connect interpretive availability to a task-specific agency loop and to distinguish agent limitation from evaluator invisibility.

4.5 Agency is not identical to resistance

Mahmood's critique of liberal-feminist assumptions is crucial: embodied practices, discipline, religious observance, and inhabiting norms can be forms of agency rather than evidence of failed emancipation [14]. The present framework therefore rejects the

Table 1: Internal programme genealogy and the residual interface identified here.

Programme object	Retained result	Role in this paper
Readout Genesis / Readout Universe	Readout is finite and reader-conditioned; retained difference, record, and world are not collapsed; history and correction matter.	Supplies the distinction between objective structure, agent readout, and evaluator readout.
Effective, Corrigible Agency Potential	Agency potential is an envelope of feasible readout–decision–execution–feedback loops; potential, performance, and evaluator visibility must be separated.	Supplies the outer feasibility envelope and the R–D–X–F agency cycle.
Experience Is Meaning-Giving	A phenomenon becomes lived experience through a constrained meaning relation; resonance, rhythm, retention, and transition readiness shape later readout.	Supplies the pre-choice meaning layer and history-shaped accessibility.
Experience Is the Human LoRA	Selected experiential residues may alter future interpretation and action without being literal neural LoRA.	Supplies cross-time operator change.
From Problem to Hypothesis	Reachability differs from accessibility; attraction and recent-path momentum can make some semantic routes easier to re-enter.	Supplies a formal precedent for live-option weighting and path dependence.
Fusion / Tunnel	Repeated Human-AI traversal can alter later accessible routes; amplification is epistemically neutral; resistance is required.	Supplies recursive coupling and the risk that repeated routes become tunnels.
CTSA Human Return	Coupled performance is not human capability; after AI removal, retained Concept, Tool, Skill, or Alternative Return must be demonstrated.	Supplies the upper measurement boundary for durable human gain.

inference that a norm-conforming choice is non-agentic merely because an outsider would prefer resistance. A live possibility field is reader-relative and normatively contestable; its evaluation must preserve the agent's own projects while still allowing independent evidence of coercion, domination, or blocked objection.

4.6 Informational control and empowerment

Klyubin, Polani, and Nehaniv formalize empowerment as agent-centric control using channel capacity from actions to future perceptions [15]. This is a close formal ancestor of any informational treatment of agency. The present paper does not claim that control, information, or action-perception loops are novel. It adds actor ownership, corrigibility, live-option accessibility, and evaluator identifiability as separate constraints.

4.7 Peace and structural violence

Galtung's structural-violence formulation is relevant because it compares actual outcomes with potential and explicitly recognizes the difficulty of specifying potential, especially in psychological domains [16]. His later account of cultural violence concerns cultural aspects that legitimize direct or structural violence [17]. The present framework uses this literature cautiously: a narrowed live possibility field is not automatically violence. A structural-violence claim additionally requires a feasible counterfactual, a responsible causal mechanism, and a normative reason why the blocked agency matters.

4.8 Human-AI feedback

Recent experiments show that repeated interaction with biased AI can alter later human perceptual, emotional, and social judgments and amplify bias [18]. The importance here is not that AI always manipulates users. It is that the human state entering a later judgment is demonstrably history-sensitive. This makes the pre-choice and pre-prompt layers empirically consequential.

5. The Core Thesis: Choice Begins Before Choice

The defended thesis is:

> *A human choice is generated from a field of possibilities that has already been filtered and weighted by meaning, history, embodiment, social structure, interpretive resources, and current context. The architecture of agency therefore begins before the moment of overt decision.*

This thesis yields five propositions.

P1 - Objective possibility is not practical possibility. An action may be physically or legally available while remaining absent from the agent's practical field.

P2 - Practical possibility is meaning-shaped. An option becomes live only insofar as the agent can in some way discriminate, interpret, imagine, value, fear, reject, desire, delegate, or otherwise relate to it as a candidate for action.

P3 - Meaning-shaping can alter agency. Changing how an option is named, framed, remembered, socially recognized, or connected to prior experience can alter whether it becomes live before any final preference or decision is expressed.

P4 - Choice can be real within a narrowed field. A person may genuinely choose among the live options available while still having a smaller effective agency field than under a feasible counterfactual. Narrowing the field does not make every remaining choice fake.

P5 - Expansion can also be harmful. Increasing the number or salience of live options is not automatically emancipatory. Manipulative, dangerous, false, or overwhelming options can become more accessible. Agency expansion therefore remains distinct from epistemic warrant and ethical value.

6. Six Levels That Must Not Collapse

Let $\Pi_t^{phys}(g)$ denote actions physically possible under the declared environment for task g. Let $\Pi_{A,t}^{feas}(g)$ denote the subset the agent could access, use, or learn within declared resources, time, and structural conditions. Define the *live possibility set*

$$\Pi_{A,t}^{live}(g) \subseteq \Pi_{A,t}^{feas}(g)$$

as those feasible policies that are sufficiently accessible to enter practical consideration under the current human state and context.

A realized choice $\pi_{A,t}^{choice}$ is selected from this live set, an enacted policy $\pi_{A,t}^{act}$ is what is actually implemented, and the evaluator observes only a record

$$Y_{obs} = \mathcal{O}_q(H_{0:T}).$$

The intended ordering is therefore

$$\boxed{\begin{aligned} &\pi^{choice} \in \Pi^{live} \subseteq \Pi^{feas} \subseteq \Pi^{phys}, \\ &\quad \pi^{act} \neq \pi^{choice} \text{ possible}, \\ &\quad Y_{obs} \neq H_{0:T}. \end{aligned}}$$

These are analytic levels, not claims that the brain contains literal option sets. Their purpose is to prevent six common collapses:

$$\text{possible} \neq \text{feasible} \neq \text{live} \neq \text{chosen} \neq \text{enacted} \neq \text{observed}.$$

An evaluator may see no objection even when objection is live but strategically withheld; may see compliance when refusal was never made safe; may see success when a third party effectively controlled the process; or may see low competence because the measurement interface hides available capacity. Agency assessment is therefore itself a readout problem.

7. A Live Possibility Field

The binary set Π^{live} is useful for exposition but too coarse for modeling. Let $\kappa_{A,t}(\pi \mid g)$ be a declared accessibility weight over feasible policies. It may depend on retained history, conceptual availability, salience, social permission, fear, expected cost, prior traversal, language, tool access, and current framing. The present paper does not assert that κ is a literal neural probability.

Define a task-relative live possibility profile

$$\mathcal{L}_{A,t}(g) = \left\{ (\pi, \kappa_{A,t}(\pi \mid g)) : \pi \in \Pi_{A,t}^{feas}(g) \right\}.$$

A declared operational threshold τ_{live} may be used for a particular study:

$$\Pi_{A,t}^{live}(g) = \{\pi : \kappa_{A,t}(\pi \mid g) \geq \tau_{live}\},$$

but the threshold is measurement-specific and should not be promoted to a universal psychological constant.

The key object is not option count but the *distribution of practical accessibility*. Two people can face the same formal menu and have radically different live fields. One may see refusal, negotiation, delegation, delay, appeal, or exit as genuine candidates; another may not.

7.1 Meaning-giving as the pre-choice gate

From *Experience Is Meaning-Giving*, a phenomenon becomes experience through a reader-conditioned meaning relation. Applied to agency, an objective affordance or formal option becomes practically relevant only after it acquires some significance for the agent. Meaning may be affective, pragmatic, autobiographical, conceptual, or epistemic. The live field is therefore downstream of meaning-giving but upstream of final choice.

This does not imply that every option must be verbally named. A person can flee danger, seek comfort, or reject an interaction before explicit lexical articulation. The claim is that some significance relation must make the route functionally available to the situated agent.

8. How History Shapes the Live Field

The live possibility field is not rebuilt from zero at each moment. Four history-shaped processes from the existing programme become relevant.

8.1 Resonance: experiential fit

Resonance is defined as congruence between a current externally prompted experience and retained internal experiential organization [2]. In agency terms, a proposal can become unusually live because it fits autobiographical memory, identity, fear, hope, or prior meaning structure. Resonance is neither consent nor warrant:

$$\mathit{Resonance} \neq \mathit{Consent}, \qquad \mathit{Resonance} \neq \mathit{Truth}.$$

A manipulative narrative can resonate. A liberating alternative can fail to resonate because it is unfamiliar. Resonance therefore helps explain uptake, not legitimacy.

8.2 Rhythm: structured return

Rhythm is structured recurrence, spacing, interruption, emphasis, and return across ordered history [2]. In agency terms, repeated exposure to a route can alter re-entry even when total content is held constant. This yields a strong but open question: does the temporal organization of how alternatives are returned to alter their later practical accessibility beyond exposure count?

8.3 Attraction and recent-path momentum

The semantic-mobility work distinguishes reachability from accessibility and proposes history-shaped attraction and recent-path momentum: recently traversed routes can become easier to re-enter for a finite window [4]. Applied here, the current live field may be biased toward the paths just used, rehearsed, socially reinforced, or institutionally normalized. Accessibility remains distinct from evidence and truth.

8.4 Retention: the next chooser may not be the same reader

Human LoRA proposes that selected experiential residues can alter the future interpretive operator [3]. This produces a crucial result for agency:

> *The person who chooses at $t+1$ may be the same biological individual but not the same effective reader of possibility as at t.*

The option field can therefore be reshaped by prior experience even before explicit beliefs or stated preferences visibly change.

9. Effective, Corrigible Agency Revisited

The earlier Agency Potential paper defines, for task g, four joint conditions: R_g for reading relevant differences, D_g for actor-directed decision or refusal, X_g for causal translation of choice into relevant action/outcome, and F_g for usable feedback, objection, and revision [1]. Its task-specific potential is

$$p^*_{A,g} = \max_{\pi \in \Pi_A^{feas}(g)} \Pr(R_g \cap D_g \cap X_g \cap F_g).$$

The present paper adds a pre-choice distinction rather than replacing this equation. At any instant, the policy actually considered must come from the current live subset:

$$\Pi_{A,t}^{live}(g) \subseteq \Pi_A^{feas}(g; h, z, T, B).$$

The feasible envelope therefore asks *what could become usable under the declared horizon and resources?*; the live field asks *what is practically available to this agent now?*

This distinction makes intervention analysis more precise. Education may enlarge Π^{live} by making alternatives intelligible. Legal reform may enlarge Π^{feas} without immediately changing Π^{live}. A safe complaint channel may increase both live refusal and F_g. AI may temporarily enlarge live conceptual routes while reducing unaided Human Return after removal. A coercive environment may leave formal feasibility unchanged while making refusal effectively non-live through credible retaliation.

10. Power Before Prohibition

The strongest political thesis of this paper is:

> ***Power can act on agency by acting on meaning before it acts on choice.***

This does not mean that all meaning formation is power in a pejorative sense, or that all norm formation is domination. Human beings necessarily learn languages, values, roles, practices, and interpretive repertoires socially. The claim is structural: because live possibility is meaning-shaped, institutions and relationships can influence agency by altering what is intelligible, legitimate, sayable, imaginable, costly, shameful, sacred, dangerous, or normal before an explicit decision is made.

Three pathways must be distinguished.

Direct closure removes a feasible route through law, force, resource denial, threat, or technical impossibility.

Interpretive closure leaves a route formally open but deprives the agent of concepts, language, credibility, or recognized standing needed to understand or communicate it.

History-shaped closure repeatedly reinforces one route while suppressing alternatives until the practical accessibility distribution becomes highly concentrated.

None of these is automatically wrongful. A safety rule may rightly close a harmful action. Professional training may beneficially concentrate expert attention. A religious discipline may be voluntarily inhabited and agentic. Wrongfulness requires an independent normative argument and, where structural violence is claimed, a feasible counterfactual and a causal mechanism.

11. Structural Deprivation and Violence

The Agency Potential work already proposes a recoverable agency gap between current conditions and feasible interventions [1]. The present paper adds a live-field diagnostic. Let $\mathcal{J}_{feas}$ be feasible structural interventions and let D_L be a declared distance between live possibility profiles. A recoverable live-field gap can be represented schematically as

$$\mathsf{L}_{A,g}^{live} = \max_{z \in \mathcal{J}_{feas}} D_L(\mathcal{L}_A^z(g), \mathcal{L}_A^{z_0}(g)) \, .$$

This is not a unit of violence. It merely quantifies how much a feasible intervention could alter the agent's practical option field under a declared metric.

A claim of structural deprivation requires at least four additional elements: (i) a specific agency-relevant capacity or live route that is blocked; (ii) evidence of a responsible structural mechanism; (iii) a feasible counterfactual rather than an imaginary ideal; and (iv) a normative reason why the blockage constitutes harm, domination, injustice, or violence. This preserves the methodological caution in Galtung's potential/actual distinction while avoiding the move from any unfulfilled possibility directly to "violence."

Cultural violence can then be studied without declaring whole cultures violent: ask whether a legitimating frame changes what can be read as permissible, what objections remain socially intelligible, whose testimony is credible, and whether feasible routes of refusal or revision remain live.

12. Consent, Compliance, and the Danger of Outsider Substitution

The live-field framework creates a danger of paternalism if used carelessly. An evaluator might claim that a person "cannot really choose" merely because the person's values differ from the evaluator's. Three protections are therefore constitutive.

First, **conformity is not non-agency**. Following Mahmood, living through a norm can itself be an agentic project. Second, **resonance is not consent**. A familiar or identity-congruent option may feel right without satisfying voluntariness or corrigibility. Third, **outsider visibility is not capacity**. The evaluator's failure to observe refusal, dissent, or alternative strategy does not prove those capacities are absent.

A defensible assessment therefore asks whether the agent can access relevant distinctions, whether acceptance/refusal is genuinely attributable to the agent under declared coercion checks, whether the choice can causally affect action, and whether objection/revision channels remain usable. It does not require the person to choose the evaluator's preferred life.

13. Human-AI: The Pre-Prompt Live Possibility Field

The Pre-Prompt Human State Principle states that Human-AI interaction begins before the current prompt because the prompt is a bounded articulation of a history-bearing human state [2]. The present paper strengthens this by identifying the live possibility field as one component of that state.

Let H_t include retained experience, current meanings, values, unresolved differences, recent interaction history, and the live possibility profile $\mathcal{L}_{A,t}$. The human exports only a bounded articulation

$$H_t \xrightarrow{L_H} Q_t.$$

The AI receives Q_t, not the whole human state. Its output Y_t is then experienced and interpreted by the human:

$$Q_t \to AI_t \to Y_t \xrightarrow{R_H} E^{AI}_{H,t}.$$

If some residue is retained,

$$H_{t+1} = U_H(H_t, E^{AI}_{H,t}, \delta^{world}, X^{other}),$$

and therefore

$$\mathcal{L}_{A,t+1} \neq \mathcal{L}_{A,t}$$

may occur before the next prompt is generated.

This yields a deeper AI-safety and AI-benefit question. Evaluating only whether Y_t is correct misses whether repeated interaction makes some routes easier to think, some objections harder to formulate, some alternatives newly live, or some previously live distinctions disappear. Glickman and Sharot's experiments establish that prior AI interaction can shift later human judgments; they do not establish the present mechanism, but they show that the history-shaped starting state is empirically real [18].

The direction remains open. AI can expand the live field by supplying language, translation, counterexamples, analogies, and routes previously inaccessible. It can also produce an epistemic tunnel by repeatedly returning the same framing, making one route fluent and suppressing alternatives. Amplification is therefore neutral:

$$\text{more live accessibility} \neq \text{better agency},$$
$$\text{more fluent choice} \neq \text{better choice}.$$

14. Human Return: Did the Expanded Field Come Back With the Person?

A live route available only while AI is present is not yet durable human agency. CTSA Human Return requires that after AI removal, the person can independently reconstruct a concept, select a tool, execute a skill, or generate a non-equivalent alternative under declared criteria [6].

This gives a temporal sequence:

$$\text{AI-assisted live possibility expansion} \to \text{retention?} \to \text{unaided re-entry?} \to \text{Human Return.}$$

A system may therefore increase coupled performance while reducing human potential if the user becomes less able to detect errors, formulate alternatives, or continue the readout-action-feedback loop without the system. Conversely, AI may temporarily do more work while leaving behind a wider and more corrigible human live field. These cases must be measured separately.

15. Non-Collapse Laws

The architecture stands or falls on role separation. The following are constitutive:

- objective possibility $\neq$ structural feasibility;
- feasibility $\neq$ live possibility;
- live possibility $\neq$ stated preference;
- stated preference $\neq$ free consent;
- choice $\neq$ enactment;
- enactment $\neq$ evaluator-visible agency;
- option count $\neq$ effective agency;
- accessibility $\neq$ warrant;
- resonance $\neq$ consent;

- repetition $\neq$ legitimacy;
- retention $\neq$ improvement;
- norm conformity $\neq$ absence of agency;
- resistance to norms $\neq$ agency by definition;
- meaning-shaping $\neq$ domination;
- live-field narrowing $\neq$ structural violence without causal and normative conditions;
- AI influence $\neq$ manipulation by definition;
- coupled performance $\neq$ Human Return.

16. Empirical Programme: Try to Kill the Theory

The theory earns a technical role only if live-field measures explain behavior beyond simpler alternatives.

H1 - Live possibility beyond formal option count [Open]. Hold the formal menu constant while manipulating interpretive access, safe refusal, language, or task framing. The live-field model should predict which options enter deliberation and later action beyond the number of available options.

H2 - Meaning access beyond resources [Open]. Hold material resources approximately constant while varying whether an option is intelligible, nameable, or linked to the agent's current problem representation. If resource-only models predict equally well, the meaning layer should be narrowed.

H3 - History-shaped re-entry [Open]. Holding current option content fixed, prior traversal history should predict which alternatives are spontaneously generated or considered. If history adds no held-out value after current state is controlled, momentum/rhythm variables should be removed.

H4 - Resonance without consent [Open]. High experiential congruence should predict felt fit or uptake but should not perfectly predict voluntary endorsement under coercion checks. If resonance and consent are empirically indistinguishable, the role separation needs revision.

H5 - Structural closure before overt prohibition [Open]. In some domains, changing retaliation risk, complaint credibility, interpretive resources, or social recognition should alter practical option use even when formal permission remains unchanged.

H6 - Evaluator visibility [Open]. Changing the assessment interface may change observed agency rankings without changing real-world readout-action capability. If all measurement variation tracks capability change, the visibility layer adds no value in that domain.

H7 - Human-AI live-field carryover [Open/externally allied]. Randomize AI dialogue histories, then hold the final prompt approximately constant and remove AI. Measure which alternatives humans can independently generate, reject, or act upon. Prior AI trajectory should affect the later live field for at least some tasks if the pre-prompt claim is correct.

H8 - Corrigibility predicts durable agency [Open]. Feedback/objection capacity should predict later error correction beyond productivity, confidence, and resource scores in tasks requiring repeated revision.

Every study should preregister rivals: resources/capability only; stated-preference models; formal option count; arousal/familiarity; schema or self-reference; current-state-only models; and reward/performance baselines. A live-field construct that adds no discriminating or predictive work should be deleted.

17. Legitimate Defeaters

The architecture should be materially narrowed if well-designed studies show that: (i) formal feasibility plus stated preferences fully predicts considered and enacted options; (ii) interpretive or meaning access adds no information once resources and incentives are controlled; (iii) prior history does not alter option accessibility beyond current-state variables; (iv) safe objection and revision add no explanatory value for later correction; (v) evaluator-interface changes never alter observed agency without changing underlying capability; (vi) Human-AI history effects disappear after current prompt and explicit memory are controlled; or (vii) the live-field vocabulary cannot be operationalized reproducibly across independent teams.

The strongest philosophical thesis could still survive some empirical failures at a descriptive level, but the technical constructs should not. The programme's deletion rule remains: *preserve the phenomenon, remove machinery that does no distinct work.*

18. Discussion: The Architecture of What Can Become a Possibility

The paper began with a deceptively simple claim: choice begins before choice. Its importance is not that humans are socially influenced; that is old knowledge. The stronger point is architectural. If effective agency is a readout-action-feedback capacity and experience is meaning-giving, then the field from which choices are generated is itself a dynamic object. It can widen, narrow, become polarized, become more corrigible, or become easier to traverse in one direction than another.

This changes how potential should be interpreted. Potential is not an inner reservoir waiting to be expressed. It is an envelope of possible loops under a world, a history, resources, relationships, and time. Current practical agency is further restricted by which parts of that envelope have become live. A person may therefore have a larger recoverable potential than current behavior reveals. Conversely, apparent confidence and action can coexist with a narrow live field and poor corrigibility.

It also changes how power is studied. Power need not wait until a recognized option is prohibited. It can operate on the conditions of intelligibility, credibility, salience, social permission, and expected consequence through which an option becomes live. This is compatible with Foucault's field of possible action, Pettit's domination, Fricker's interpretive injustice, Kabeer's conditions of choice, and Galtung's concern with potential, while adding a readout-native measurement interface.

The same architecture prevents an opposite mistake: treating every socially shaped desire as false consciousness. Social formation is unavoidable. Resonance with a tradition, role, or religious practice can be genuinely agentic. The critical questions are not whether the choice is culturally formed but whether relevant alternatives can become intelligible, whether acceptance/refusal is attributable to the person, whether the choice can have causal effect, and whether objection and revision remain possible.

Human-AI systems intensify the problem because they can alter the human possibility field recursively and quickly. A model response can provide a missing concept, normalize an alternative, repeat a frame, reduce switching cost, or make one narrative feel increasingly natural. The next prompt is partly generated from that changed field. Therefore AI evaluation that freezes the human as a static input source misses a central causal pathway.

19. Standalone Thesis

> ***Human agency begins before overt choice.*** *A finite person does not choose from the full space of what is objectively possible, but from a history-shaped field of possibilities that have become sufficiently meaningful, accessible, discriminable, and actionable to function as live candidates. Experience gives significance to phenomena; retained experience changes the future reader; resonance can make some possibilities experientially fitted; rhythm and repeated traversal can make some routes easier to re-enter; social and institutional power can expand, suppress, or structure these routes; and AI can recursively reshape the field from which the next prompt and choice arise. Effective agency therefore requires more than options or outcomes: it requires the corrigible capacity to read relevant differences, own acceptance or refusal, causally enact a decision, and preserve usable routes of objection and revision. Power can act on agency by acting on meaning before it acts on choice. Yet meaning-shaping is not automatically domination, resonance is not consent, accessibility is not truth, and a narrowed field counts as structural deprivation only when a feasible counterfactual, a responsible causal mechanism, and a defensible normative loss are shown.*

20. Conclusion

The central implication is methodological. Asking only "What did the person choose?" begins too late. Asking only "What options existed?" remains too external. Asking only "What did the evaluator observe?" confuses the person's capacity with the measuring interface. A fuller analysis asks: what was physically possible, what was feasible under actual resources and structure, what became live for this reader, what was chosen, what could be enacted, what feedback remained available, and what the evaluator could legitimately infer.

This sequence reveals a hidden architecture of human potential. Meaning, history, and structure do not merely decorate choice after the fact; they help determine what can become a choice at all. The resulting theory neither denies the world nor dissolves agency into discourse. It treats agency as a situated, causally effective, corrigible loop whose option field is meaning-shaped and historically revisable. In Human-AI systems, that means the epistemic and agentic trajectory begins before the prompt. The decisive question is not only what the system helped a person do, but **what became newly possible to see, think, refuse, imagine, and choose - and what remained available to the human after the system was gone.**

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